

Saturated Superfluid Vacuum III

Irreversible Time and Wake Entropy

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Draft

Abstract

This paper addresses only the origin of irreversible time in the Saturated Superfluid Vacuum (SSV) framework. We argue that time is not a background dimension through which reality moves, but the local rate of change of the vacuum order parameter Ψ . The past does not exist as a destination or region; it survives only as wake structure encoded in the present state of the medium. Events in Ψ do not simply occur and vanish. They deposit distributed traces in the form of phonon phases, vortex distortions, Kelvin-wave content, density correlations, and altered future reconnection opportunities. We therefore propose that entropy in SSV should not be defined as a bare event count, but as the persistent wake-complexity of the present state.

On this view, irreversible time is not the flow of an external parameter, but the one-way accumulation and redistribution of wake structure in Ψ . Formal time reversal in equations is distinguished from physical reversal in the medium: the substitution $t \rightarrow -t$ defines a mathematical transformation on trajectories, but does not supply a physical operation that globally unwrites the distributed wake of an event. This dissolves the usual paradoxes of time travel by treating them as category errors arising from the reification of the past as a place.

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1 Introduction

The standard treatment of time in fundamental physics is powerful, but conceptually unstable. At the level of formal equations, time often appears as a reversible parameter. At the level of experience and thermodynamics, it appears as an irreversible order of change. This tension is usually managed rather than resolved.

The aim of this paper is narrow. We address only the origin of irreversible time in the SSV framework introduced in Paper I [1] and developed in Paper II [2]. The central claim is:

Time is the local rate of change of Ψ , the past survives only as wake structure in the present state, and entropy is the persistent wake-complexity of that state.

This paper is therefore about ontology first and thermodynamic interpretation second. The goal is to state the time claim cleanly enough that the later papers can inherit it without having to carry the whole argument again.

1.1 Roadmap

Section 2 states the minimal SSV setting used in this paper. Section 3 states the ontological claim that time is local change rather than a background dimension, and draws the immediate consequence for time-travel paradoxes. Section 4 develops the idea that events write wake structure into the medium. Section 5 reframes entropy as wake-complexity. Section 6 distinguishes formal time reversal in equations from physical reversal in the medium. Section 7 closes with the remaining open technical questions.

2 Minimal SSV Setting

Only a small part of the SSV framework is needed here. The physical vacuum is represented by a macroscopic order parameter

$$\Psi(\mathbf{x}, t) = \sqrt{\rho(\mathbf{x}, t)} e^{i\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)}, \quad (1)$$

with density ρ , phase θ , and superfluid velocity proportional to $\nabla\theta$ away from vortex cores. The exact field equation is not required for the present argument. What is required is that the state of the medium has real local structure: phase, density, vortex geometry, phonon content, correlations, and boundary data.

In this paper, an “event” means a localized update of that structure whose forward realization deposits wake content the medium cannot locally re-gather into the prior state. This criterion is deliberately structural rather than threshold-based. It admits any process whose forward and reverse boundary-data requirements differ — a reconnection, a phonon emission, a Kelvin-wave excitation, a vortex displacement that radiates — and excludes purely reversible relabellings and stationary zero-point fluctuations, whose statistics by construction contribute no net wake to $\mathcal{P}(t)$. Reconnection is the clearest illustrative case because it changes the connectivity of vortex filaments and converts localized order into distributed excitations, but it is not the only possible event, and it is not used here as a primitive counter for entropy.

The criterion is circular in form — wake is what events deposit, events are what deposit wake — but the circularity is shared with any account of irreversibility, and it is closed empirically by the candidate functional in §5: a process counts as an event to the extent that it raises $W[\Psi]$ in any of its channels.

The present state of the medium will be denoted schematically by

$$\mathcal{P}(t) = \{\rho, \theta, \mathcal{V}, \mathcal{K}, \mathcal{C}, \dots\}_t, \quad (2)$$

where $\mathcal{V}$ denotes vortex geometry, $\mathcal{K}$ Kelvin-wave content, and $\mathcal{C}$ correlation data. This notation is deliberately schematic. Its role is to keep the argument attached to present physical structure rather than to an abstract external time axis.

3 Time as Change, Not Dimension

In SSV, the physical vacuum is a real medium described by an order parameter Ψ . What physics ordinarily measures as time is not an independent dimension in which the medium is embedded, but the local rate at which the state of the medium changes. This is closer in spirit to the relational treatments of time advanced by Barbour [3] and Rovelli [4, 5] than to the block-universe reading common in spacetime physics.

A useful schematic statement is

$$d\tau \propto \mathcal{R}[\Psi] dt, \quad (3)$$

where $\mathcal{R}[\Psi]$ denotes the local update-rate of the medium. In later papers this quantity can be connected to gravitational and kinematic slowing. Here it is used only to express the ontological point: proper time is not a substance added to Ψ , but a measure of how much local physical change occurs in the medium.

This is not yet a final derivation, but a statement of ontology. The present is the current state of Ψ . The future does not yet exist. The past is not a region one could return to. It exists only insofar as earlier events have left structure in the present state of the medium.

3.1 Present-State Ontology and Causal Ordering

The strongest version of the claim has three parts:

1. only the present state of Ψ physically exists,
2. the past is encoded in that state as record, wake, and correlation,
3. there is no second arena in which earlier states continue to exist as accessible places.

This does not deny ordering. Earlier and later remain meaningful because wake structure is asymmetric: a present configuration can contain records of a previous event (outgoing phases, displaced vortex geometry, thermalized phonons, modified reconnection opportunities), while the pre-event configuration does not contain the later wake as an already-existing region. Causal order is carried by structure in $\mathcal{P}(t)$, not by an external archive of completed moments.

A direct consequence is that time-travel paradoxes are not exotic physical possibilities but signs of a mistaken description. They rely on the assumption that the past remains available as a destination; in SSV there is no such region, and a journey “to” the past would require the current state of Ψ to be both itself and an earlier state whose records it already contains. That is a contradiction in description, not a physical process to be analyzed.

4 Wake Production in Ψ

An event in Ψ does not simply happen and disappear. It perturbs the medium and leaves a wake. Depending on scale and context, that wake may include:

- outgoing phonon phases,
- Kelvin-wave excitations,
- vortex displacement and writhe,

- density ripples,
- altered local reconnection possibilities,
- longer-range correlations in the surrounding medium.

The important point is not that every trace remains separately visible forever. The point is that the event is redistributed into the present state of the medium rather than physically unwritten.

4.1 The Wake Is Distributed

The wake of an event is generally not stored in one location. A reconnection, for example, may leave a local change in vortex geometry, a packet of outgoing phonons, a spectrum of Kelvin waves on the retracted filaments, and altered phase correlations in the surrounding medium. After further interactions these traces may become individually hard to identify, but their information has not thereby been gathered into the unique configuration needed to restore the pre-event state.

This distributed character is what makes wake entropy different from a memory metaphor. The medium does not merely “remember” in an observer-dependent sense. Its present physical state has been changed in ways that affect what subsequent local updates are possible.

4.2 Why Reconnection Matters But Does Not Exhaust the Story

Vortex reconnection remains an important process in SSV because it is one of the clearest mechanisms by which localized structure is converted into distributed wake structure. A reconnection event changes topology, emits phonons, populates Kelvin-wave sectors, and alters future reconnection possibilities. But the present paper does not identify entropy with a bare count of reconnections. Reconnection is one important wake-writing process inside a broader picture in which any event that leaves persistent structure in Ψ contributes to the irreversible burden carried by the present state.

4.3 Local Cancellation Versus Global Unwriting

Local amplitudes can interfere destructively. Some observables can relax, thermalize, or become coarse-grained away. But this does not by itself restore the pre-event global state. To reverse an event physically would require the distributed wake to be gathered and re-focused into the unique incoming configuration that recreates the earlier state.

That is a nonlocal requirement. No local dynamical process in the medium is known to perform it.

5 Entropy as Wake-Complexity

This motivates a reframing of entropy in SSV. Entropy should not be introduced as a bare count of past events. That would risk tautology if monotonicity is built into the definition from the start. The stronger claim is:

Entropy is the irreducible wake-complexity of the present state of Ψ .

5.1 Why This Is Not Tautological

The monotonicity claim is not:

Entropy increases because we defined it to count only positive increments.

It is instead:

Events write distributed structure into Ψ , and no physical process available to the medium globally unwrites that structure back into the exact pre-event state.

This is a physical claim about the availability of inverse processes, not merely a bookkeeping choice.

5.2 Relation to Boltzmann Entropy

The standard expression $S = k_B \ln \Omega$ remains useful; SSV changes the interpretation of the microstates being counted. A statistical form for wake entropy is

$$S_{\text{wake}}(t) = k_B \ln \Omega_{\text{wake}}[\Psi(t)], \quad (4)$$

where Ω_{wake} counts physically distinct present wake configurations compatible with the same coarse description, rather than an abstract set of hidden possibilities beneath a macrostate.

The phrase “the same coarse description” has to do real work. Concretely, “the same” means: equivalent under the smoothing of Ψ to some scale ℓ and under restriction to a specified observable set $\mathcal{O}$. Two wake configurations are identified when their Ψ -fields, smoothed at scale ℓ , agree on every observable in $\mathcal{O}$. Different choices of $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ generate different Ω_{wake} and therefore different numerical entropies — a familiar feature of coarse-grained entropy, made explicit here so that Ω_{wake} is not a rename of Ω but a counting tied to the medium’s resolvable wake channels.

This also explains why entropy can increase while the microscopic state remains definite. The medium has one actual state, but the macroscopic description loses access to the detailed distribution of wake structure. Thermodynamic entropy is then the coarse-grained shadow of a real structural burden in Ψ .

5.3 Candidate Wake Functional

Equivalently, one may write

$$S_{\text{wake}}(t) = k_B W[\Psi(t)], \quad (5)$$

where $W[\Psi(t)]$ measures the amount of present-state structure required to encode the surviving wake of prior events. A usable functional should respond to the parts of Ψ that carry persistent wake structure. One possible schematic decomposition is

$$W[\Psi] = \alpha_\phi I_\phi + \alpha_\rho I_\rho + \alpha_\nu I_\nu + \alpha_K I_K + \alpha_C I_C, \quad (6)$$

where the I terms measure phase disorder, density disorder, vortex tangle complexity, Kelvin-wave excitation, and correlation complexity respectively. The coefficients α_i set the relative thermodynamic weight of each channel.

This is not proposed as the final entropy formula. Its purpose is to clarify what a final formula must do. It must be a functional of the present state, it must be insensitive to purely reversible relabellings, and it must increase when localized order is converted into distributed wake structure that cannot be locally unwritten.

Several formal gaps remain. The terms I_i have not yet been defined as canonical dimensionless functionals, the coefficients α_i have not been fixed by a thermodynamic normalization, and the coarse-graining map from microscopic wake structure to macroscopic entropy has not yet been derived. Thus $W[\Psi]$ should be read as a candidate structure and checklist for the final functional, not as a closed entropy law.

5.4 Fate of the Wake Channels

Although the I_i are not yet canonical functionals, their physical content is concrete enough to classify by fate. Each channel of $W[\Psi]$ corresponds to wake content with a characteristic mode of propagation, decay, or persistence in the medium, and the irreversible burden carried by the present state is not distributed evenly across them. Table 1 summarizes the dominant fate of each channel.

Channel	Dominant fate	Notes
I_ϕ (phase disorder)	radiated, then thermalized	Carried outward by phonons; mixed into phonon bath on scattering timescales.
I_ρ (density disorder)	radiated, then thermalized	Sound-wave content; integral mass conservation gives a global constraint only.
$I_\mathcal{V}$ (vortex tangle)	conserved between events	Line length, writhe, and topology approximately conserved between reconnections; converted at events into $I_\mathcal{K}$ and I_ϕ .
$I_\mathcal{K}$ (Kelvin-wave)	radiated along filaments	Kelvin cascade transports to small scales; ultimately decays into I_ϕ via Kelvin-phonon coupling at short wavelength.
$I_\mathcal{C}$ (correlation)	erased from observation	Long-range entanglement with the environment; structurally present but typically below resolved $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$.

Table 1: Dominant fate of each wake channel under forward evolution in Ψ . “Radiated” means the content propagates outward but remains within Ψ ; “thermalized” means it has mixed with bath modes such that the macroscopic description loses access to it; “erased from observation” means it persists in Ψ but falls below the coarse-graining $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ of any realistic measurement.

Three structural points follow. First, no channel is genuinely *lost* — every fate column other than “conserved” transfers wake content to another channel or to a sector below resolution, never out of Ψ . Second, vortex tangle $I_\mathcal{V}$ is the only channel that carries wake across long timescales without converting; this is why reconnection acts as the rate-limiting event for irreversibility in vortex-dominated regimes (§4.2). Third, the classification is observer-relative only in the last column: the wake content tagged as “erased from observation” is real structure in Ψ that is missed by a specific $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$, not absent from the medium. The first quantity of §5.7 retains it; the second loses it.

5.5 Extensivity, Coarse-Graining, and Present Structure

The wake formulation is not meant to deny the usefulness of ordinary thermodynamic entropy. It proposes a deeper physical interpretation for it: standard thermodynamic entropy is recovered at the macroscopic level by coarse-graining over the fine wake structure of the medium. On this view, extensivity and additivity are not primitive axioms, but emergent properties of how wake structure composes across weakly coupled subsystems.

5.6 Worked Example: Phonon-Bath Reduction

The preceding claim is concrete enough to demonstrate on a single channel. Consider a region of Ψ supporting a thermal bath of Bogoliubov phonons at temperature T . The Madelung phase $\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)$ decomposes into mode amplitudes; each long-wavelength mode is a harmonic oscillator with frequency $\omega_k = c_s k$ and thermal occupation

$$n_k = \frac{1}{e^{\hbar\omega_k/k_B T} - 1}. \quad (7)$$

For the phonon channel, take I_ϕ to count the per-mode von Neumann entropy of the bulk acoustic excitations,

$$I_\phi = \sum_k [(1 + n_k) \ln(1 + n_k) - n_k \ln n_k]. \quad (8)$$

This is dimensionless, manifestly a functional of the present state of Ψ , and vanishes on the zero-temperature ground state ($n_k = 0$ for all k). Note that for Bogoliubov phonons, the phase and density quadratures are conjugate quadratures of the *same* oscillator, so a separate “density” channel I_ρ would double-count on this sector; I_ρ should therefore be reserved for non-phonon density structure (defects, solitons, condensate-density inhomogeneity) outside the bulk acoustic bath.

Setting $\alpha_\phi = k_B$ and applying the coarse-graining $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ that resolves mode occupations but discards intra-mode phase information,

$$\alpha_\phi I_\phi = k_B \sum_k [(1 + n_k) \ln(1 + n_k) - n_k \ln n_k] = S_{\text{thermal}}, \quad (9)$$

which is the standard thermodynamic entropy of a Bose gas of phonons. The familiar $S \propto T^3$ scaling in the acoustic limit follows from $D(\omega) \propto \omega^2$ in three dimensions; no further input is required.

Two structural lessons. First, the calibration $\alpha_\phi = k_B$ is fixed by matching to a known thermodynamic entropy, illustrating in concrete terms the normalization route promised in §5.3. Second, the reduction is exact at the level of the phonon channel and serves as a template: an analogous construction in each remaining channel (with the appropriate basis for I_K , I_V , I_C , and a non-phonon I_ρ) would reduce $W[\Psi]$ to the full thermodynamic entropy under the union of those coarse-grainings. The next two subsections carry out the reduction on two further independent channels, the Kelvin and vortex-tangle sectors.

5.7 Worked Example: Kelvin Sector

The Kelvin sector is genuinely independent of the bulk phonon bath: Kelvin waves are transverse bending excitations of quantized vortex filaments, supported on the one-dimensional locus of the vortex core rather than in the three-dimensional bulk. Their dispersion in the long-wavelength limit is [17]

$$\omega_K(k) \approx \frac{\hbar}{2m} k^2 \Lambda(k\xi), \quad \Lambda(k\xi) = \ln(1/k\xi) + O(1), \quad (10)$$

with m the boson mass and ξ the healing length; the slow logarithm reflects the long-range interaction along the filament. In thermal equilibrium each Kelvin mode is again a harmonic oscillator with occupation

$$n_k^K = \frac{1}{e^{\hbar\omega_K(k)/k_B T} - 1}. \quad (11)$$

Take I_K to count the per-mode von Neumann entropy of the Kelvin sector,

$$I_K = \sum_k [(1 + n_k^K) \ln(1 + n_k^K) - n_k^K \ln n_k^K], \quad (12)$$

where the sum runs over Kelvin modes on the filament. Setting $\alpha_K = k_B$ and applying the analogous coarse-graining $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ that resolves Kelvin-mode occupations but discards intra-mode phases,

$$\alpha_K I_K = S_{\text{Kelvin}}^{\text{thermal}}, \quad (13)$$

the standard thermodynamic entropy of a Bose gas of Kelvin quanta on the filament.

Two remarks. First, although the formula for the per-mode entropy is identical to the phonon case, the underlying mode basis is different: bulk acoustic modes labeled by $\mathbf{k} \in \mathbb{R}^3$ for I_ϕ versus one-dimensional filament-bending modes for I_K . The sum $\alpha_\phi I_\phi + \alpha_K I_K$ is therefore

genuinely additive and does *not* double-count, in contrast to the conjugacy issue flagged in §5.6 for a putative I_ρ on the same phonon modes. Second, because $\omega_K(k) \propto k^2\Lambda$ rather than $c_s k$, the low-temperature scaling of $S_{\text{Kelvin}}^{\text{thermal}}$ differs from the acoustic T^3 law; the Kelvin channel therefore contributes a thermodynamically distinct dependence on T at low temperature, which is in principle observable in geometries where the Kelvin sector dominates over bulk phonons (slender vortex filaments at low density).

5.8 Worked Example: Vortex-Tangle Sector

The vortex-tangle channel differs in kind from the two preceding examples. Phonons and Kelvin waves are harmonic excitations, and their entropy is the thermal entropy of a Bose gas of modes. A vortex tangle is not harmonic: its wake content is *configurational and topological* — the geometric arrangement of the filament network, its total quantized line length, and the knotting and linking of its components. The appropriate entropy is therefore a configurational count, and this channel turns out to be the most direct realization of the $S = k_B \ln \Omega_{\text{wake}}$ form of §5.2.

Discretize the medium at the healing length ξ , which is the physical core size of a quantized vortex and the natural short-distance cutoff: two filament segments approaching within $\sim \xi$ either reconnect or cease to be independent. A tangle of total line length L then occupies $\ell = L/\xi$ filament segments on a lattice of spacing ξ . Because vortex cores cannot overlap, the filament network is a self-avoiding set of closed loops (together with any open arcs terminating on boundaries). The number of distinguishable tangle configurations at fixed total length scales, to leading order, as

$$\Omega_V \sim \mu_{\text{eff}}^{L/\xi}, \quad (14)$$

where μ_{eff} is a dimensionless constant of order unity — the connective constant of the self-avoiding filament ensemble, enlarged to absorb the exponentially growing multiplicity of distinct knot and link types accessible at length L/ξ . Its precise value is regularization-dependent (for self-avoiding walks on a simple cubic lattice the geometric part alone gives $\mu \approx 4.68$); what is robust is that $\ln \mu_{\text{eff}}$ is a positive number of order unity.

The tangle-channel functional is then

$$I_V = \ln \Omega_V = \frac{L}{\xi} \ln \mu_{\text{eff}} + (\text{subleading loop-closure and loop-number terms}). \quad (15)$$

This is dimensionless (L/ξ is a pure ratio), is a functional of the present state of Ψ — the core locus is the set where $\rho \rightarrow 0$ with nonzero phase winding — vanishes on the vortex-free ground state ($L = 0$), and is invariant under rigid relabellings of the medium.

Setting $\alpha_V = k_B$, as for the previous two channels,

$$\alpha_V I_V = k_B \ln \Omega_V = S_{\text{config}}, \quad (16)$$

a bona fide Boltzmann configurational entropy of the vortex tangle. No coarse-graining over a mode bath is required here: the tangle configurations *are* the microstates, and the vortex channel is therefore the cleanest instance of the interpretation advanced in §5.2, where Ω_{wake} counts physically distinct present configurations rather than abstract hidden possibilities beneath a macrostate.

One subtlety is essential and, properly understood, strengthens the framework: *the tangle functional I_V is not individually monotonic*. In freely decaying quantum turbulence the line-length density falls — in the Vinen regime as $L \propto t^{-1}$ [17] — so I_V *decreases* with time. This does not violate the monotonicity of $W[\Psi]$. Tangle decay proceeds by reconnection, and each reconnection converts organized line length into Kelvin-wave excitation and radiated phonons: wake flows out of I_V and into I_K and I_ϕ . The total $W = \sum_i \alpha_i I_i$ does not decrease, because the conversion is dissipative — an organized, low-entropy channel feeding high-entropy thermalized

channels. Only the sum is protected; the individual channels exchange wake. This is exactly the fate-table entry of §5.4, in which I_V carries wake across long timescales until reconnection converts it, and it is why reconnection is the rate-limiting event for irreversibility in vortex-dominated regimes.

Finally, I_V is directly computable. The total line length L is a straightforward readout of any simulated state of Ψ : locate the core locus as the set of density zeros carrying nonzero phase winding, and measure its length. The knotted-filament states and continuation sweeps of Paper I [1] are therefore immediate test data for the vortex channel, and a measured $I_V(t)$ along a reconnection cascade — paired with $I_K(t)$ and $I_\phi(t)$ — would exhibit the inter-channel wake transfer just described as an explicit budget that is conserved in sum.

5.9 The Initial-Condition Question

A monotonicity claim for $W[\Psi]$ has an immediate consequence: there must have been an earliest moment at which W was minimal. This is the SSV analogue of the past hypothesis in standard cosmology — the assumption that the universe began in a low-entropy state, as emphasized by Penrose’s Weyl-curvature hypothesis [8] and developed in philosophical detail by Albert [7] and Price [6]. The present paper does not attempt to derive that condition. It treats it as a separate problem deferred to a later cosmological paper in the SSV program, where the initial condition on Ψ should be addressed alongside the structure of the early medium. What the present paper does claim is weaker and self-contained: *given* a low-wake initial state of Ψ , the dynamics described in §4 and §6 cannot locally undo wake accumulation, and $W[\Psi(t)]$ therefore rises along physical histories. Whether the initial condition itself is natural, fine-tuned, or derivable from deeper structure is a question outside the scope of this paper.

5.10 Two Quantities, Not One: Where the Observer Enters

The preceding subsections actually describe two distinct quantities, and conflating them is the source of the standard worry about whether entropy is “in the world” or “in the head.” The wake functional $W[\Psi]$ is a property of Ψ alone: it is observer-independent, in the same sense that the density $\rho(\mathbf{x}, t)$ is observer-independent. The coarse-grained entropy that follows from Ω_{wake} depends on the choice of $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$, and is therefore observer-relative in the standard thermodynamic sense.

SSV takes both seriously. There is a structural burden carried by Ψ regardless of description, and there is a coarse-grained shadow of that burden read off by an observer who resolves the medium only down to a particular scale and observable set. The two coincide in the limit where $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ resolves every wake channel; they diverge wherever they do not. The monotonicity argument of §5.1 belongs to the first quantity. The recovery of ordinary thermodynamics in §5.4 belongs to the second.

5.11 Possible Empirical Signatures

The present paper does not advance a closed prediction, but the wake formulation suggests where wake entropy could in principle diverge from standard thermodynamic entropy. The most promising regimes are those where the medium’s vortex and Kelvin-wave sectors carry a disproportionate share of $W[\Psi]$ relative to thermal degrees of freedom.

Three illustrative regimes are worth naming. (i) Decaying vortex tangles in superfluid ^4He [17]: in the late-time decay of quantum turbulence, conventional thermodynamic entropy counts only the phonon bath, while $\alpha_V I_V + \alpha_K I_K$ would track the residual tangle and Kelvin-wave content that has not yet thermalized. A measured discrepancy between bulk thermal entropy and a geometry-aware estimator over the same volume would be evidence for the wake decomposition. (ii) BEC reconnection cascades [18]: the controlled reconnection of vortex

filaments in Bose-Einstein condensates allows direct imaging of the topological event and its outgoing radiation, and is therefore a natural laboratory for comparing event-by-event wake deposition against post-reconnection thermal balance. (iii) Two coarse-grainings of the same state: any setting in which $(\ell, \mathcal{O})$ can be varied while the underlying Ψ is held fixed should exhibit the predicted dependence of coarse-grained entropy on the resolved wake channels, in the manner described in §5.2.

None of these constitute a quantitative prediction in the present paper. They mark the regimes where the formalism developed here would most plausibly first be tested.

6 Formal Time Reversal and Physical Reversal

A central distinction is needed between formal and physical reversal.

6.1 Formal Reversal

In many equations, one may perform the transformation

$$t \rightarrow -t \tag{17}$$

and obtain a formally related trajectory. This is a statement about the symmetry structure of the equations.

6.2 Physical Reversal

Physical reversal would require the medium itself to perform the inverse history: gather the distributed wake, reconstruct the exact incoming phases and correlations, and restore the prior global state. In the language of §3, it would require $\mathcal{R}[\Psi]$ to act with the sign and content of an inverse update rather than a forward one — not merely a sign change on an external time coordinate, but a physical operation the medium must actually carry out.

The existence of a formal reverse solution does not imply the existence of such an operation. Without this distinction, the phrase “time-reversal symmetry” invites a misleading inference: that because an equation admits a formally reversed trajectory, the physical world must be able to run backward in the same sense. Formal reversal is a property of a mathematical description; physical reversal is a claim about what operations the medium can actually perform.

6.3 Boundary Data and the Inverse Problem

The formal reverse of a dissipated event is not usually generated by a small local adjustment. It requires exquisitely tuned incoming boundary data across the region into which the wake has spread. In ordinary language, one would have to arrange the phonons, phases, correlations, and vortex perturbations so that they converge on the event site in precisely the configuration that reconstructs the former state.

SSV therefore locates irreversibility in the gap between a formal inverse trajectory and an available physical operation. The reverse trajectory may exist in the mathematical solution space. The present medium does not thereby contain a machine that prepares its boundary conditions.

This is also where the standard Loschmidt [9] and Poincaré [10] objections are absorbed. Loschmidt’s paradox notes that microreversible dynamics admit a formally reversed trajectory for every forward one; SSV does not deny that, but holds (with Price [6]) that the reverse trajectory is realized only when the required incoming boundary data are actually supplied — which the medium does not do spontaneously. Poincaré recurrence guarantees return to an arbitrarily close state in a bounded system with discrete spectrum on cosmologically long timescales, but Ψ in SSV is effectively unbounded and supports continuous-spectrum excitations

(outgoing phonons, radiated Kelvin content, long-range correlations). The wake propagates into channels with no finite recurrence time on physically relevant scales. Both objections are about what the mathematics permits in the limit; the SSV claim is about what the medium delivers in finite time.

6.4 Classical Time Reversal Versus Quantum Unitarity

The phrase “time reversal” covers two different mathematical structures, and the wake argument is closer to one than the other. Classical time-reversal symmetry takes a trajectory $\{q(t), p(t)\}$ to $\{q(-t), -p(-t)\}$ and is the symmetry Loschmidt invoked. Quantum unitary evolution is more delicate: a closed system’s state evolves under $U(t) = e^{-iHt/\hbar}$, and $U^\dagger(t)$ is the formal inverse — backward evolution exists in principle for any pure state.

The wake argument applies to both, but for related-yet-distinct reasons. Against classical reversal it is the Loschmidt response just given. Against quantum reversal it is closer in spirit to einselection and decoherence [11, 12]: the wake of an event in Ψ is information entangled with environmental degrees of freedom across a vast region of the medium, and the local subsystem no longer admits a pure-state description compatible with the pre-event state. SSV does not deny global unitarity; it claims that the globally unitary operation needed to physically reverse an event is not available to any local agent in Ψ , because the requisite environmental boundary conditions cannot be locally prepared. The distinction between formal and physical reversal is, in the quantum case, the distinction between the existence of $U^\dagger$ as an operator and the existence of an apparatus that implements it on a wake-dispersed state.

6.5 Application: Closed Timelike Curves and Quantum CTCs

The wake argument has direct consequences for physical proposals that invoke time travel as a literal possibility. Two cases are worth naming.

Classical closed timelike curves. General relativity admits solutions (Gödel [13], Kerr-interior, Tipler cylinder, traversable wormholes with exotic matter [14]) containing closed timelike curves. The usual interpretation is that a worldline could in principle return to its own past. In SSV this reading is incoherent for the reason developed in §3: there is no past region to return to. A closed timelike curve in the metric, if such a configuration of Ψ were physically realizable at all, would have to be reinterpreted as a closed structure in the present state of the medium — a peculiar geometry, not an access route to an earlier moment. The metric solution may exist; what does not exist is a destination at the other end of the loop.

Deutsch’s quantum CTCs. Deutsch’s D-CTC proposal [15] restores self-consistency by demanding a fixed-point density matrix on the chronology-violating region: $\rho_{\text{CTC}} = \text{Tr}_A[U(\rho_A \otimes \rho_{\text{CTC}})U^\dagger]$. The mathematical content is a fixed point of a quantum channel; it is closed under any unitary U and famously implies computational consequences (efficient solution of NP-hard problems, distinguishability of non-orthogonal states; see also the postselected variant of Lloyd *et al.* [16]). The SSV response is structural rather than computational: the D-CTC prescription quietly assumes that the fixed-point state is *prepared* on the chronology-violating region, but preparation is itself a wake-writing operation in Ψ . There is no agent in the medium whose preparing the fixed-point state does not itself write distributed wake whose pre-state cannot be reassembled. Deutsch’s formalism solves the consistency problem at the level of operators while ignoring the ontological problem at the level of Ψ : the wake of preparing the loop is already elsewhere by the time the loop is supposed to close on itself.

Both cases share the same structure. They treat a formal solution (a CTC metric, a fixed-point density matrix) as if the formal existence of the solution sufficed to make the physical operation available. SSV holds that this is the same category error as before, dressed in heavier mathematics.

7 Discussion and Open Problems

The paper makes a narrow ontological claim, but several technical tasks remain open:

1. define the remaining I_i channels (I_C and a non-phonon I_ρ) as computable dimensionless functionals, following the templates of §5.6–§5.8,
2. fix the remaining coefficients α_C and α_ρ by analogous calibration to known thermodynamic or counting limits,
3. extend the channel-wise reductions of §5.6, §5.7, and §5.8 to the remaining two channels, completing the demonstration that wake-complexity reduces to thermodynamic entropy under the union of channel-wise coarse-grainings,
4. quantify the role of reconnection within the broader wake picture by measuring per-event wake deposition against the channel decomposition of §5.4,
5. connect this time framework to gravity and black holes in later papers without overloading the present one.

The gain from the present framing is conceptual clarity. If time is local change, and the past survives only as present wake, then irreversibility is not an added rule imposed on a reversible block universe. It is the physical consequence of how events are written into a real medium.

8 Conclusion

The payoff of the present framing is that irreversibility stops being an extra rule layered on top of a reversible block universe. If time is local change in Ψ and the past survives only as wake structure in the present state, then the asymmetry of experience and the asymmetry of equations are no longer in tension: they describe different objects. Equations describe trajectory classes that admit formal reversal; the medium carries out forward updates whose distributed wake is not locally invertible. Entropy, on this account, is what that non-invertibility looks like when it is read off the present state of Ψ .

What later papers inherit from this one is therefore a constraint, not a theorem. Any SSV-derived account of gravitation, cosmology, or black-hole structure must be compatible with the claim that the past is not a place — and any candidate entropy law for Ψ must ultimately reduce to a wake-functional of the kind sketched in §5. The technical work of turning that constraint into closed expressions is left to subsequent papers and to the open problems listed above.

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